

PRODUCTION KITCHEN

Three years at the vineyard, then the door shut behind me.

Everything after it was somewhere else — the same job, learned over again in a room that did it differently.

Australia was first.

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I landed with a suitcase, a knife kit, and absolutely no idea what I'd signed up for.

Big move for a young chef who'd only just been given CDP. New country. New kitchen. New everything.

The motto was already entrenched by then: *How hard could it be?*

Turns out, that question has layers.

I'd never worked in a hotel. Never mind a resort. The stopover on the way over was the first time I'd stayed in a hotel as a guest. Now I was supposed to work in one.

In the middle of the fucking desert.

Nothing for miles except red dirt, heat shimmer, and a kitchen I couldn't picture no matter how hard I tried.

The job title was Demi Chef of Production Kitchen.

Started at 7 a.m.

I didn't know what a production kitchen was.

But I'd said yes, packed my life into baggage allowance, and turned up anyway.

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I arrived at 06:30.

Standard. You come early, you claim your space, you get your bearings before the room fills with bodies and the energy of service.

Except there's no one there.

Just me. And Gavin. The Executive Chef.
I'll come back to him.

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Changed into whites. Apron tied. Boots laced.

Walked to Chef's office, knocked on the doorframe.

"Good morning, Chef. I'm looking for the production kitchen—here for my first shift."

Gavin looked up from his desk.

Smiled.

"Good morning, sir. Come, take a seat."

Sir?

Take a seat?

I'm more accustomed to *muppet, puppy, bozo*. I don't think I've ever sat down in uniform before. Standing is the default. Sitting is what you do when service is over and your body gives up.

I sat.

For exactly two seconds.

It didn't feel right.

I stood again.

"Production kitchen, Chef?"

Gavin stood. Didn't say anything. Just walked me down the hall to a room I wouldn't have called a kitchen if you'd paid me.

No ovens.

No burners.

Just benches. A couple of deep sinks. Two walk-in chillers. Not even a dishie area.

What the fuck is this.

"Dane and Rob—your sous chefs—will be in at seven. Feel free to have a look around."

Two sous chefs?

These guys must get absolutely fisted.

"Thanks, Chef."

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I pulled up a chopping board.

Wet a cloth, slid it underneath.

Sharpened my knife.

The familiar rhythm settled me for about thirty seconds.

Then I looked around. Really looked.

And that's when I saw it.

In the sink.

Fish.

Frozen fish. Sitting in a sink full of water. Just... there. Like someone put it in and fucked off to a different postcode.

What muppet put fish in a sink of water and left it there?

And why in God's name was it frozen to begin with?

I'd never seen frozen fish in a professional kitchen. Ever.

And I'd definitely never seen fish left in a sink full of water like it was some kind of fucking baptism.

I drained the sink. Grabbed a holey gastro. Got the fish draining properly.

All the while on the verge of a breakdown because Chef's going to walk in, see me standing over this disaster, assume it's mine, and fire me before I've even clocked on.

What the actual fuck.

I was used to standards. The kind beaten into you by people who don't accept "good enough."

And this?

This was not that.

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07:00.

The sous chefs arrived.

Scraggly uniforms. One of them wearing his glasses on top of his head like a fucking headband. They looked like they'd just woken up.

Maybe they had.

"G'day, mate. You must be Chris."

"Yes, Chef."

I gestured at the sink.

"Wasn't sure where the prep list was. Found the fish though—think it might have been frozen."

"That's okay, mate. We'll just grab a coffee. Fish is fine—one of the boys must've left it. Just... cut some vege sticks till we get back."

What have I done.

This may possibly be the worst decision I've ever made.

These guys are my seniors.

And it's nearly seven. Where are the others?

I bit my lip. Said nothing. Got to it.

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Five minutes.

Four one-litre containers. One of each colour bell pepper. One of cucumber.

Perfect one-centimetre batons. Uniform. Clean.

The kind of knife work that doesn't need checking because it's already right.

I figured they'd need a dip for the day as well.

Grabbed a couple of shallots, the pepper trimmings, some pine nuts, and went looking for an oven.

Fuck me dead.

There's a whole bank of combis down the hall. Three other kitchens. The breakfast crew halfway through their shift.

I jumped into one of the free combis, roasted everything up nice and golden, headed back to production, and smashed out a quick roast pepper and sundried tomato dip.

Done.

But now what?

It's 07:00.

Where the fuck are the others?

And where is my sous?

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07:10.

Dane and Robbie walked back through the doors.

They froze.

Looked at each other.

Looked at me.

Looked at the prep.

Back at me.

Dane picked up a baton. Held it up to the light like he'd never seen one before.

Maybe he hadn't.

When he said "vege sticks," he meant sticks. Roughly stick-shaped. Near enough.

I didn't know that language yet. Where I came from, words meant something specific. You asked for batons, you got batons. One centimetre. Uniform. Clean. Anything less and you'd be doing them again while someone explained—loudly—why your time was now their problem.

These two had been here long enough to become part of the furniture. Comfortable. Under the radar. They knew how to get the job done and go home without anyone noticing either way.

Precision wasn't the expectation.

It was a foreign object.

"Haha, holy shit, mate. You've only been here ten minutes."

Forty minutes, actually.

You've been here for ten.

But I didn't say that.

Just nodded.

"What's next, Chef?"

* * *

That was day one.

The first of many days where I'd realise that "production kitchen" meant something completely different to what I'd been trained for.

No pass. No service. No dockets screaming at you while you juggle six pans and a ticking timer in your head.

Just prep.

Bulk prep. For functions, buffets, room service, the restaurants I'd never work in.

It wasn't bad.

It just wasn't what I knew.

And for someone who'd spent three years learning that speed and precision and pressure were the whole point, this felt like being benched.

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Weeks passed like that.

Show up. Prep vegetables. Break down protein for events I'd never see.

Make dips, sauces, garnishes for rooms I'd never step foot in.

Clock out. Go home. Repeat.

I started to think there wasn't even a service kitchen in this place.

Then one night—coming back from an on-site function—I heard it.

That familiar sound.

A docket machine.

New order.

Yes, Chef.

I followed the sound like a junkie chasing a fix.

Down the corridor. Into the main kitchen area—usually buzzing with various teams during the day. Commissary, breakfast, staff canteen.

All gone now.

The space empty except for one little corner.

Four chefs.

Uniforms crisp. Clean.

Sections neat. Organised.

Plates under the lights.

Wait staff in three-piece suits, arms bearing waiters' cloths.

This.

This is what I'd been looking for.

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I found a spot near the wall where I wouldn't be in the way.

Just watching.

The chefs were all different nationalities. An older Vietnamese man appeared to be running the kitchen—calling times, checking plates, moving between stations with that economy of motion you only get after decades on the line.

I'd never seen a kitchen that wasn't entirely European. Still multinational, just... European.

This was different.

A table headed off from the pass. A brief moment where the Vietnamese chef looked over to me.

"It's okay if I watch for a while, Chef?"

"All good, mate."

Broken English. Thick Vietnamese accent.

But the meaning clear.

I stayed.

Watched them work through the last of the evening's service. The rhythm was familiar—the same quiet intensity I'd known in New Zealand. Chef's voice. Responses. The sound of pans and plates and controlled movement. No wasted words.

But it was unmistakably service.

Real service.

When they started wrapping up—close to 23:00—I asked if they needed a hand to clean down.

"All good, mate. Soon."

Maybe he didn't understand me. *Soon?*

I stayed a little longer before heading home.

It was like a new lease on life. There was hope. A chance.

I just had to get into that kitchen.

* * *

Little did I know, it was already in motion.

The sous in production had already asked to have me transferred.

A day or so later, I turned up at 06:30 as I did every day. Got changed. Headed up the corridor, said hello on my way past Chef's office as I walked toward production.

Then I got stopped.

The exec sous—a Filipino woman who also ran the pastry kitchen—stepped into my path.

"Chef wants to see you."

Wants to see me.

Fuck.

This can't be good.

I followed cautiously back to Chef's office. Knocked on the frame.

"Yes, Chef."

"Good morning, sir. Come in, take a seat."

"Is everything okay, Chef?"

The door closed behind me.

* * *

It was nothing to worry about.

Gavin just wanted to let me know I wouldn't be in production anymore.

As of my next shift, I'd be heading to the fine dining kitchen.
That high.
That excitement.
It was back.

* * *

The sous chefs asked to have me transferred.

I found that out later. At the time I thought Gavin had been watching.
Turns out Dane and Robbie just didn't know what to do with me.

Fair enough.

I didn't know what to do with them either.